

Where are you in your AI journey?

This is not a quiz about what you know. It is a worksheet about how your business actually works. Fill it in honestly, in order, and you will finish with a clear read on three things.

01

Whether your business is ready to start at all.

02

Which single process to start with, and why that one.

03

Which stage you are actually at, and the one move to make next.

AI adoption is not a technology problem. It is a business design problem.

Which is why this workbook never asks which tool you use. The right question is not “which AI tool should I buy?” It is “which workflow should I redesign first?”

THE FIVE STEPS THIS WORKBOOK FOLLOWS

A pipeline, not a menu. Skip a step and the next one has nothing to stand on.

01	WATCH	Where are time and money actually going?
02	TEACH	What does “better” mean, and what rules must be respected?
03	EXPERIMENT	Which alternative performs better, before we change reality?
04	PRODUCTIZE	How do we make the winning method repeatable for everyone?
05	DELEGATE	What can AI execute, and where must a human remain in control?

Work through the parts in order. Each one uses the answer you gave in the part before it.

Should your business start with AI at all?

AI accelerates the systems you already have. If those systems are inconsistent, AI amplifies the inconsistency, faster and at scale. So before anything else, five checks. “Almost” counts as a no.

☐ **We have product-market fit. We know who buys from us and why.**

AI cannot compensate for an unclear value proposition. If you are still searching, validate the business first.

☐ **Our core processes repeat the same way each time.**

Not reinvented per job, per client, per person. If work happens differently every time, standardise it before you automate it.

☐ **Our data exists somewhere digital.**

In files, sheets or a system, not only in people’s heads, notebooks and WhatsApp threads.

☐ **We can name the business outcome AI must move.**

Revenue, profit, cost, speed or customer experience. “Using AI” is not an outcome.

☐ **If we are in a regulated industry, we know which rules apply.**

Compliance, governance and data security get decided before AI touches a critical workflow, not after.

TICKS

out of 5

4 OR 5 TICKS

Carry on to Part 2. You have enough structure for AI to stand on.

3 OR FEWER

Do the unticked one first. Standardise the process, get the data in one place, name the outcome, then come back to this page. Starting now buys you an expensive experiment, not a result.

Where are you actually, right now?

Six stages, in order. Tick every stage you have genuinely completed and circle the last one. Be strict: a tool somebody tried once is not a workflow, and a pilot nobody uses is not Stage 4.

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- | | | |
|--------------------------|---------|---|
| ☐ | Stage 1 | The outcome is defined
We have named the business number AI must move, and it is written down. |
| <hr/> | | |
| ☐ | Stage 2 | The workflows are mapped
Each department broken into the work it actually repeats, not its org chart. |
| <hr/> | | |
| ☐ | Stage 3 | They are prioritised by return
We know which workflow is repetitive, data-rich, time-consuming and tied to the outcome. |
| <hr/> | | |
| ☐ | Stage 4 | One workflow is built and in use
A single AI workflow runs in the business regularly, used by people other than whoever built it. |
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| ☐ | Stage 5 | It has scaled sideways
The same pattern repeated in other departments, and the pieces connected to each other. |
| <hr/> | | |
| ☐ | Stage 6 | The operating model is AI-native
AI supports decisions and execution across functions. The company observes itself and improves itself. |
-
- MY STAGE
TODAY

☐

Everything that follows is how you finish the next stage, not all six.
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Nobody jumps stages. Companies that try to transform everything at once usually end up back at Stage 1, having spent a lot.

Where is your time and money actually going?

List the five processes your business repeats most often. Not projects, the recurring ones: the report someone rebuilds every Monday, the quotes compared by hand, the same twelve follow-ups. Then cost them out.

#	THE PROCESS WE REPEAT	WHO DOES IT	TIMES / MONTH	HOURS EACH	HOURS / YEAR
1					
2					
3					
4					
5					

IF YOU MAKE THINGS

“Comparing five vendor quotes for the same list of items by hand in Excel. Purchase team. 20× a month. 2 hrs each. **480 hrs a year.**”

IF YOU SELL DIRECT

“Pulling last week’s orders, returns and ad spend into one sheet to decide what to push. Founder. 4× a month. 3 hrs each. **144 hrs a year.**”

Circle the row with the highest hours-per-year figure, then write it here.

This one process carries through the rest of the workbook. One, not five.

One process. Four answers.

Answer for the process you circled. If an answer takes a paragraph, the process is still too big, so narrow it.

02 **TEACH** What does a **good** output look like, and what rule must never be broken?

Making: “Good = true landed cost per unit, freight and tax included. Never quote a price the file doesn’t support.”
Selling: “Good = margin after returns and ad spend. Never count a refunded order as revenue.”

03 **EXPERIMENT** What is the smallest test that proves AI does this better than today?

Shape it like this: “I will run **last month’s ten real cases** through AI and compare against **what we actually did**. It wins if **time halves with no error I would have caught**.”

04 **PRODUCTIZE** If it wins, who else must be able to run it without asking you?

Then tick the shape it takes:

- ☐ a saved prompt ☐ a project holding our own files ☐ a written method anyone can load
☐ a dashboard ☐ a scheduled routine ☐ a real app

05 **DELEGATE** Which part must a human still approve, and why?

The rule: repetitive → automate it · needs judgment → AI drafts, you decide · money, legal or customer-facing → a human signs off, always · everything else → let AI lead.

Is this the right first project?

Score the experiment you wrote in Part 4. A project that fails two or three of these may still sound exciting, but it is the wrong place to start.

S	Seen	Can the AI observe the necessary video, documents, logs or data?	☐
E	Economic	Is there a measurable cost, delay, defect or revenue opportunity?	☐
N	Narrow	Can the first experiment be limited to one process?	☐
S	Safe	Can mistakes be reversed, isolated or human-approved?	☐
E	Evidenced	Can you compare the result against a benchmark?	☐

SENSE
SCORE

4 or 5, start here. 3 or below, pick a different process from Part 3 and score again.

FOUR WAYS THIS GOES WRONG

Buying software and calling it transformation.

A subscription is not a redesigned workflow.

Treating AI as magic.

It is magical. It is not magic. Assume it will get things wrong and design for that.

Chasing headcount cuts on day one.

The valuable projects usually raise revenue, quality and decision speed too.

Handing it to IT.

This is a business transformation, not an IT purchase. It belongs with leadership and the people who own the process.

So where does that leave you?

FROM PART 1 Pre-check ticks, out of 5	FROM PART 2 Your stage, out of 6	FROM PART 5 SENSE score, out of 5
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Find the first row that matches you, top to bottom. Do the one move in it, not the three below it.

Pre-check 3 or below	Not yet. Fix the foundation. Pick the single unticked item and close it first. Standardise the process, or get the data out of people’s heads and into one place. AI will amplify whatever you leave broken.
SENSE 3 or below	Right intent, wrong first project. Go back to Part 3, take the next process down the list, and score it again. The first project’s job is to produce evidence, not excitement.
Stage 1–2	Ready to start. Run the experiment. Take recent cases where you already know the right answer, run them through AI and compare the two results. One process, one honest verdict.
Stage 3–4	It works. Now stop re-explaining it. Write the method down once, the rules, the format and the exceptions, then hand the same one to everyone who does this job. After that, repeat on a second workflow.
Stage 5–6	Connect it, and put decisions on a schedule. Join the working workflows into one system, decide what runs without a human and what never will, then take your next five processes through this workbook.

WRITE YOUR ONE NEXT MOVE HERE

Run your five highest-value processes through Watch, Teach, Experiment, Productize and Delegate, and you will not have five AI tools. You will have a company that can observe itself, improve itself, and repeat what works at scale.